

Hollerbier Haven

Newsletter for Herbal and Healing Arts



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As the year draws to a close, it is traditionally the time to look back and reflect on all that we have learned and experienced in the last twelve months. Equally important, we celebrate 'All Souls Day' as the time to remember those teachers and loved ones who have passed and to reflect on their contributions during their time here on earth.

At the Three Sisters Center, our workshops and guild gatherings are finished for 2007 so we look forward to the quiet winter months to catch up on a few projects that were carefully put on a shelf while we completed our teaching and writing responsibilities. Interviewing elder Brauchers and documenting their teachings is a project that we hold dear to our hearts.

This break in outward activity also gives us time to reconnect with each other and reformulate our visions and goals for the coming year. We each have course curriculums to organize (see pages 17-18) and 2008 guild meetings to plan for. Please watch for the next issue of Hollerbier Haven newsletter in early February and visit our website in early 2008 for a complete calendar of events. Until then....

Mir wunsche eich alle en heiligem un frolichem Neiyaahr.

(We wish you all a Holy and Happy New Year)

Blessings, Jesse and Susan



Soul Work on Halloween

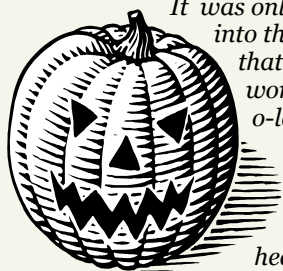
By Dennis Boyer

The Pennsylvania Germans were often at their most unreserved around Halloween, with a fair amount of tolerance for mischief of various types. In the time of our fathers and grandfathers there were areas with hardly an upright outhouse greeting the dawn of November 1st. Blazing haystacks, farm equipment hoisted to barn roofs, and even the occasional blasphemous assemblage of household furniture upon church steeples was the stuff of boyhood legends.

While such antics prompted grumbling in some quarters, there were seldom sharp responses or demands for revenge or restitution (though this writer and his co-conspirators were shot at by one intoxicated objector to a prank in the Seisholtzville neighborhood). On the whole the male world of the Dutch chalked such things up as youthful accomplishments on par with a good fastball pitch or decent shot on a first deer.

The old men long past such behavior could nevertheless enjoy such tales—all the more if the memories were enhanced by hard cider

Meanwhile the female half of the Dutch world was caught up in the production of various treats and preparations of costumes. Hordes of little ones had to be organized for the rite of trick or treating and arrangements made for parades. Suffice it to say that we Dutch stayed busy at this otherwise tranquil season.



It was only later when fate took me deeper into the ancient cosmology of our tribe that I came to any inkling that other work was afoot in this season of jack-o'-lanterns and scary masks. An October trip to Hensingersville to meet with Susannah let me know that serious endeavors were undertaken by the guardians of our health and welfare.

My Grandmem Bauer always said that we need to make sure that everyone is safe on Halloween. What she meant by that is that those of us who are Pow Wow Mammies are responsible for getting our relatives and neighbors through this sensitive time. That means charms for the boys doing foolish things, remedies for the old men nipping at the jug, and soothing tea for the old ones whose nerves are rattled by the noise and mischief.

But she also meant that we were to take care of their souls and our own souls in this time when the curtain between this world and the afterlife is most threadbare and easily torn by scoundrels on either side. She thought this was an excellent time to use the access across the veil to ask questions of the wise ones and do certain types of healing. But she also saw danger for the uninitiated and the careless if they dabbled with spiritual practices beyond their skills or accidentally triggered a breach at this time of year.

She felt that those with too little strength were particularly vulnerable to losing energy to what she called the "life suckers" of the other side. She thought that children were particularly vulnerable, especially if they were exposed to too much fright. She said we could make charms against that, but that the best guard against a life sucker was to keep children laughing. "Susannah", she said, "keep the little ones laughing at the skeletons and the horrible masks and then no ugliness can steal little pieces of their souls away".

She told me that when I was quite young, but was already learning to Pow Wow. I didn't quite understand that at first and had the idea that the soul was one solid piece and that the life suckers could cut a chunk out of it. Working with Grandmem brought me to see that it was more like a collection of spiritual energy, like burning coals. We need to have a certain amount to function properly and we need certain types for certain things or we'll be out of balance. Sort of like how different parts of the brain control certain functions.

Over time I learned that soul work involves keeping these parts working together, keeping them moving in the same general direction, and pulling back the ones that were either stolen or let go. It's some of the most difficult work of Pow Wow. But as I say, Halloween is a good time for it if you know what you are doing. It's not only good because of the thinness of the barriers at this time, but also because people are more open to this type of thinking and less resistant to the strange things you might ask them to do.

I found that you really need to think carefully on how you diagnose what someone needs for soul work. It doesn't pay to get excited about some little crumb of soul wearing off from normal wear and tear. For most people that is like losing a finger tip, they can live fine without it. But for some, like a Pow Wow Mammy, we may need that particular part even if it is small. We also need to relax about how tight that soul material needs to be. It's probably a good thing if it's all in the same neighborhood and moving in the same direction. Pow Wow work is probably good exercise for keeping it that way. Still, you can be too concerned about having it in a tight little bundle. That's almost like constipation.

Grandmem Bauer told me about another Pow Wow Mammy who needed help. I think it was the one from New Tripoli. That other Pow Wow Mammy had helped a lot of people pass over, she was able to ease death in a way that helped the dying and their families. But Grandmem said that is the type of work where you must be careful not to let some of yourself go in the process. I guess that's what happened to the New Tripoli lady. Grandmem worked up a Halloween pow wow for her that pulled back some of that energy. They were able to find those departed soul's and ask for it back in a prayerful way that honored the contract of healing that help should be respected, even after death. The healing contract turns to a curse if it is dishonored, even the dead know that and can be reached by it.

Continued on page 3...

"Be careful of who you touch around that time", Grandmem said. She advised to direct the soul work with smoke or steam, not touch. Otherwise you might be exchanging pieces that you didn't intend to. A very skilled Pow Wow Mammy might be able to do otherwise, but I don't fool around anymore. I had it backfire both ways. I did a pow wow where it seemed a young girl had been hexed to rob her of energy. But I now know that she was leaking soul energy. Some of hers came into me when I wasn't careful. It felt good to me and I really had to scold myself to put it back in her. Another time I was working to get a piece of soul energy back into an old man. It was hard because he was weak and his whole bundle of energy was starting to unravel like yarn from a sweater. I got it back in, but in the process a dark intruder energy from elsewhere came into me from him and I worked like the dickens for weeks to get it out.

I think it helps to have a way of looking at these things so that you can explain them to others. You probably need one way to explain it to those you are helping, something that comforts them and gives them a mental picture of what the work is like. Then you need another way to explain it to those you are teaching, something that goes to their heart and melts right into their intuition so that they don't have to think about it much. The picture that works for me is that of soul fragments. If you think about all this as you would fractures, re-attachment, mending, and so forth then you can get a handle on it. I don't think it works to think of lost soul pieces as puffs of ether way out in the cosmos. In Pow Wow work you have to understand that everything, the afterlife and the other worlds, is right at hand. That's why the work goes easier at Halloween. Then you can think of it more like setting and splinting a broken bone. Or stopping the bleeding and wrapping a cut. Those are the ways of thinking that have worked for me.

But the other reason to work with Pow Wow at Halloween is how easy it is to reach out to teachers on the other side and get valuable information. I sense that all the wise ones from since the beginning are right there for the asking. The trick is to make contact.

There was a time when Pow Wow Mammies knew how to do this, but it is fading fast like other things about Pow Wow. I don't worry about that fading as much as I once did because I now know that all knowledge can be found again. That's the beauty of working with the wise ones. They are right there for when interest and situations call upon them. Doesn't matter if it's next week or in a thousand years.

Those who went before did this work in several different ways. Some went to a trance after taking certain herbs. Others reached across in dreams. Those were the two most common ways of asking the wise ones for help in soul work. The most common questions being "where is the soul fragment and how do I coax it back". But Grandmem Bauer talked about all sorts of other ways. Everything from staring into fires to dancing a special jig to lying in a specially made pow wow coffin. I heard from others about going into caves, springhouses, and old wells.. I guess there was even one long ago old Pow Wow Mammy who was called the Smokehouse Mammy who did her soul work in her smokehouse so that she smelled like bacon and ham all the time.



The story was that she was doing the work late one Halloween and some local boys came to rock the smokehouse off the foundation. They didn't know that she was in there and her mind was far off with the wise ones so she didn't hear them coming. Anyway, when they starting rocking the building it startled her something awful, like being shook awake in the middle of a good dream. She tipped off the bench and touched her rear end to a smoldering stump. She screamed like a wildcat and it made the boys jump. Then she started swearing like a wattohausmann *. Her cloak had some sparks on it so she threw it out the door and stepped out to beat it with a broom. The boys saw her in the glow of a kerosene lamp and looked at a face blackened by smudges and thought a witch was beating one of them with the broom and that sparks were flying off the poor fellow. They ran around the corner and into the bake oven wall. They knocked themselves out.

Now some say that she revived them with a bucket of cold well water. But others say she put a curse on them for what they had done and sealed it by pouring her chamber pot over their unconscious heads. Those who follow this version say that those boys were later known as Schneidebuwe + and left no heirs. So I guess she cursed the manhood right out of them.

That means that Grandmem Bauer was right when she said that a Pow Wow Mammy is most powerful around Halloween and that if you fool around with one it's like playing with a loaded gun.

* a tavernkeeper

+ a gelding, neutered



The Wild Hunt

The mythological legend of the Wild Hunt is the story of Mother Earth herself. In ancient times she had many names (Hel, Holle, Perchta, Bertha, Berka, Hulda, etc), but her story was always the same. She was goddess of the underworld, guardian of the dead, and the spirit of the earth itself. Her consort was Woden (Odin, Wotan), the all-father of Germanic and Nordic mythology. Together they rode the wheel of the year bringing wealth and sustenance in the summer months. In the winter months their ride was of an entirely different nature.

Though Holle acted as guardian over nearly all of the dead, Woden kept watch over all those slain in battle. Those in Woden's charge were said to feast in his hall at Valhalla until the end time battle. Those in Holle's charge remained in her cold hall beneath the earth until they were ready to be reborn. Holle had a magical mill in her possession and when a soul was ready to make the transition she would grind them up in her mill- to cast off the chaff of life (the identity of the individual), and return the soul to the purity of spirit. The soul was then able to be reborn to the world. Those souls that remained behind were too pained and tortured from their human lives to be able to purify themselves in this way. This is where our notion of being "in hell for all of eternity" comes from. Woden's charges were inherently wounded souls, having died in the horrors of war. Both Woden and Holle housed and cared for the wounded souls of the dead as they had cared for and protected them in life.

After the final harvest of the year Holle and Woden were no longer bound to the soil as they had been during the growing times. In folklore and mythology it was believed that these two were released from the earth, trailing behind them the forlorn souls they guarded. This image of thousands of the wounded souls of the afterlife springs to mind when we think of Halloween and the haunting silence of the winter months.

The biggest question is why do they come? Why do they bring these spirits up from the graven earth and fill our living world with chaos? The answer is that these spirits need our help to be at rest. All souls day has always been a day to pray for the peace of these restless spirits. In the traditions of the pagans, Catholics and many protestant sects this day was set aside in order to help those on the other side who might still be tortured by their earthly deeds. Though our religions have changed, the names and themes of the wild hunt are still present in our folk lore and even still in our religion. Regardless of faith, there are still those who beg our help to cross through the veil. Holle and Woden bring their faces and stories to the forefront as the ghosts of winter time strengthen and make themselves known. This is not an act of malice, but wisdom on their part, for they know humanity well. They know that we humans too easily shirk our duties unless those duties are thrust upon us.

Prayers for the dead can do their work through the spirit world during the dark half of the year. All Souls Day is just one day, but in folklore we are told that the wild hunt continues its flight until May 1st when their power is lost in the world of the living and they must return to the duties of the soil.

To ride along with the Wild Hunt continue to page 9

Hex Signs are perhaps one of the most ambiguous artistic expressions proceeding from the Pennsylvania German culture. Adorning the facades of German-style bank-barns across the south-eastern mid-section of the state, these rosettes and geometric star designs inspire awe and ask of us to question, from whence did they originate and with what intention were they created?

We need look no further than the names by which they have been called to discover a multitude of possible implications. Hex signs, “Blumme-Schterne” (German for flower stars), and barn stars are all terms, which indicate a relationship between humans and the celestial. The term barn star appeared in response to the widely used term Hex sign, as a scholarly attempt to clarify what was believed to be a miss-association between the symbols and the occult. However obscure esoteric knowledge is not necessary to see that these symbols take the shapes of celestial bodies. Suns, moons, and stars appear to reference the human interest in our relationship to the heavens, to the seasons, and our place in time. The orbits of the stars not only define our concepts of time, but our forbearers used the stars to orchestrate the details of their planting and harvesting, ultimately their livelihood. These symbols carry the strength and wisdom of thousands of years of observation of the heavens and an understanding of humanity's place in the vast universe. The term “Blumme Schterne” takes this idea one step further by linking the observation of plant geometry with celestial design, almost as if to remind us that as it is above, so it is below. Blossoms are revered for their fragile beauty, their medicinal benefits, and their intensity of color. One could see Hex signs as combining the elements of celestial understanding with the beauty and beneficence of flowers.

On one hand, academic researchers would have us believe that these elaborately painted symbols have little or no meaning beyond folk decoration and that they function merely as emblems of local identity. On the other hand, popular opinion tends to favor the more carefully constructed commercial interpretations which can be traced to the folk-culture craze of the 1950s and 60s. Both of these explanations leave much to be desired in bringing these symbols to light. While both describe the full range of possible contemporary interpretations today, both fail to establish a firm connection to the attitudes of our forbearers and their motivations for painting them. And let us be honest with ourselves for a moment - we must remember that we can never completely understand the beauty and complexity of the past, we merely accept one agreed-upon, constructed, historical fiction or another.

The earliest historical record would have us accept that hex signs appeared shortly after the Civil War, when commercial paints became widely available, and farmers wanted their barns decorated. However many examples exist that tell us a different story. These were signs used as date plaques, inset into the original masonry of the gable ends of barns possibly dating to just before the turn of the 19th century. One such example can be found just north of Lenhartsville on Rt 143, in Berks County.

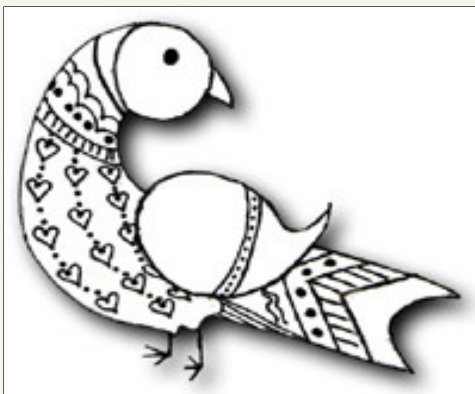
While new evidence continues to appear to challenge our notions of when these signs first appeared on barns, there is no question that these symbols have been a part of our culture for thousands of years. For the past several centuries these star designs appear on everything from dower chests and other furniture, to tools, pottery, and illuminated documents such as birth and baptismal certificates. Some scholars point to this as evidence that the symbols on barns bear no special significance because of their profusion on common, everyday objects. But on the contrary, this could mean that these symbols were held in such high esteem that they found their way into every aspect of life, that the symbols were not only meant to adorn but also to remind us of our celestial origins and our connections to the sacred cycles and patterns of all life.

Most importantly, Hex signs speak for themselves through the powerful vibration and rotation of their beauty, form and symmetry. Look upon these symbols and observe their affect upon you. Feel the awe-inspiring vision of their presence that transcends all interpretation. Look upon them with joy and move with them through the cycles of life.



Steve Kreiser demonstrating the painting of a hex sign in Kutztown at the PA German Cultural Heritage Center's Harvest Fescht on October 13-14, 2007. You can find more fine examples of his work at www.PaBarnSigns.com

-Article submitted by Patrick Donnuyer



“There was a story of the four birds of powwow, four guardians and guides. They were helping spirits in healing and magic. The first one is the Dystelfink (Thistle Finch), the bird of beauty. The Dystelfink is the main spirit creature of the Dutch, it’s a female symbol, a symbol of rebirth, the symbol of connection to spirits, and it ushers in new powwow practitioners. Dystelfink is the main guardian of powwow. The second bird is

called the “Sonnadler”, (the Sun Eagle). Sonnadler is the bird of power, and a male symbol. It charts the day, and connects to power in its more direct energetic forms. The symbol of the Sonnadler guides the young powwow practitioner into the practice, and on life’s path as well. The third bird is the “Elbedritch”. The Elbedritch is a mystical animal usually talked about in tales where he is simply silly, or mischievous. In Powwow, though, the Elbedritch is the bird of magic. It is another male symbol, and is connected with tricks and spells, and it shapes the mature powwow practice. The final one is the “Goldeneil” (the Golden Owl) which is the bird of healing. It’s a moon symbol, female, and it shapes the practice of the oldest powwow practitioners, and those, especially who are training other powwow practitioners. Goldeneil is the symbol of the White Haired Woman, the first Powwower, and the greatest guide we have on the powwow path.”

-Story taken from Braucherei oral tradition

“Men are probably
nearer the central
truth in their
superstitions than in
their science.”

- Henry David Thoreau



Early 18th Century PA German Fraktur featuring the Distelfink

Shared History — Shared Wisdom

By Matthew Sicher

It is often said that “no one is an island”. That may be true, but some languages are. Pennsylvania German (*Pennsylfawnisch Deutsch*) is known as a “linguistic island”. It is a Germanic dialect completely geographically surrounded by a different, dominant language (English). The Pennsylvania Dutch people have insisted on retaining a unique “island” not only of language, but also of wider culture since coming to Pennsylvania.

This ongoing commitment to our Mother tongue (*unser Mutter Shprooch*) has put dialect-speakers in an interesting position. Because the Pennsylvania German dialect has been largely removed and isolated from the rest of the German-speaking world, many words have become archaic. Middle High German was the origin language for all the Rhineland dialects, and many words common in the dialects are so archaic they are not to be found at all in standard High German.

There is another dialect that grew out of Middle High German. There is a sister language to Pennsylvania German, and that is Yiddish. Upon becoming more fluent in Pennsylvania German, I was delighted to find that all of a sudden I could understand a significant amount of Yiddish! Not only did both dialects develop from Middle High German, but also in many of the same regions of what is now Germany.

The German peoples who eventually moved to America came primarily from the Palatinate region of Germany. This is an area on the Rhine River including the cities of Mannheim, Heilbronn, and Karlsruhe, and extending north to Mainz, and South as far as Bern and Zurich. As early as the eighth century, there was a flourishing Jewish culture along the Rhine River. By the tenth century a “Golden Age” in Jewish intellectual history had begun in Mainz, Germany. Not only were Jewish and non-Jewish peoples all living in intimate proximity, but during this heyday of Mainz Jewish culture, Jews from all over the world migrated to Mainz, and many non-Jewish people converted to Judaism.

For better or worse the Ashkenazi Jews and Pennsylvania Germans have more in common than just location. Both suffered intense persecution, and both were eventually forced to flee the lives they had built in the Palatinate. Though forced to seek sanctuary elsewhere, both cultures left their shared home speaking a shared language. Even before fleeing the Palatinate, the Jews of the region had been forcibly isolated, and it was from this isolation that Yiddish first emerged as a unique dialect.

The increasingly archaic German spoken by Ashkenazi Jews eventually incorporated elements of Hebrew,

Aramaic, Slavic, and Romance languages, and emerged as Yiddish. Because of these other linguistic influences, there are some Yiddish words that are totally different than PA German words, but approximately seventy five percent of the Core Words of PA German and Yiddish are similar (cognates). To all of you readers who are either PA German speakers or Yiddish speakers, I encourage you to look into your sister language. I certainly found myself inspired and amazed to find not only a sister language, but in some ways a sister culture.

The experiences of both many Ashkenazi Jews and many non-Jewish Palatinate Germans, fleeing persecution, were similar. The First Crusade, and following waves of oppression eventually made many German Jews flee, especially farther East. By 1250 major Jewish migrations further east had begun. Martin Luther’s Reformation, the Thirty Years War, and draught sent many Rhinish Germans coming to Pennsylvania. These were peoples who both had rich spiritual histories (in which much was shared with their Jewish brethren). They wanted to practice their faith and live their lives in peace. Both peoples were shunned and prevented from doing so simply because they were in the minority, “in this world but not of it”, and were thus easy scapegoats. Both peoples have always been surrounded by a dominant culture, and yet have admirably sustained their own cultural sensibilities. Both cultures are part of a long tradition of deeply religious and community-based lifestyle.

The early Germans settled Pennsylvania (beginning in 1683) with the specific intention that it be “The Holy Experiment”. The goal of these Pennsylvania settlements was that they would be based on piety, hard work, and religious tolerance. Our German forbearers were frequently educated people and master farmers.

I hereby extend the humble prayer that we too may remember these original high ideals as we continue our lives one generation after another in this blessed land. I encourage all who are interested in cultural survival to realize our ancestor’s dreams of “the Time of the Lily”, and to recall the connections Pennsylvania German speakers have with Yiddish speakers worldwide. May we all choose to use this shared history, come together under one roof, and rekindle a connection between two deeply inspiring cultures that our ancestors experienced, and our descendants deserve to know. We are indeed still part of a Holy Experiment, if we so choose.

The Wild Hunt Begins....

It's been this way for centuries, perhaps millennia.... On all Hallow's Eve the wild hunt, released from the earth by the last harvest, begins its ride through the winter sky. It roams the earth until the spring with May eve (April 31st), the night when lady summer finally finds refuge from their hunt. Every child knows of the ghosts, ghouls, witches, elves, fairies, and goblins that are unleashed on Halloween night, but few today remember the gods of old that guide them on their frosty flight.

All Hallow's Eve ("Alle Liebe Ziel" in Pennsylvanisch Deutsch) is one of the oldest and most important holy days to the northern European tradition. It can be traced to early Celtic times when the year was split into two pieces: light and dark, warm and cold, summer and winter. Halloween, or as it was then called "Samhain" (pronounced "Sow'en", and meaning literally "summers end") marked the beginning of winter. More importantly than this, however, it marked the New Year.

In many ways the Celts had very different views than modern people. For one, they believed absolutely in the process of reincarnation. Their belief was firmly rooted in the truth of nature: We can watch as a tree that once was living dies, falls to the ground, its life ended. To the Celts, however, this death was nothing more than a rebirth, as it does not take long until the tree is covered in moss, fungi, and insects. Eventually the tree becomes the earth itself, seedlings sprouting up through the rich soil of decay. The Celts believed that life began with death, and death was celebrated with the same fervor as birth, it was simply renewal, continuation of the cycle.

Because of their strong faith of life in death, the Celts believed that life began in darkness, as a child in a womb. Just as they honored the deceased with rites of renewal, they honored the new day at sunset, and the New Year at Halloween, as the sun wanes in earnest and leads us to the darkest part of the year. Many of the animals held as most sacred by the Celts (often thought to be messengers of the gods) were scavengers, beings that are not held with the highest esteem in modern times: Ravens, magpies, dogs, wild pigs. The Celts saw clearly that these animals created life out of death. From the rotting remains of death they fed themselves and their young.

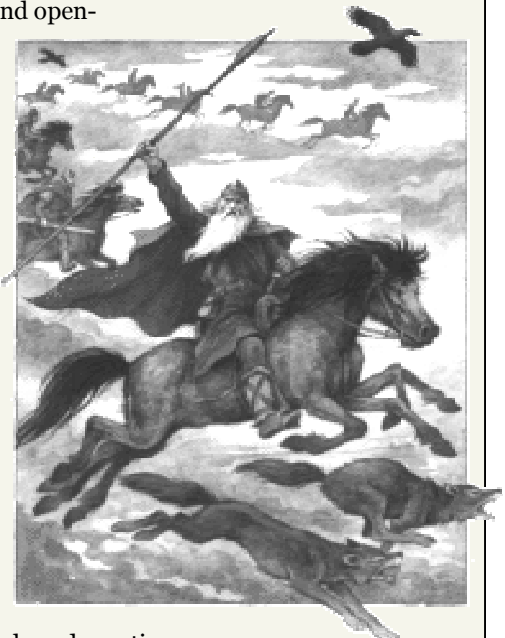
To modern people this focus on death may seem morbid, even evil, but to our indigenous ancestors, death was as sacred as any other passage: birth, coming of age, marriage. In their beliefs and rites they taught that each individual must pass through their own darkness before they can come into the light of their lives. This is meant, of course both literally and figuratively: we pass through death before we return to life just as in every challenge in life we must pass through the dark night of the soul before we can come to the peace and openness that brings us closer to harmony with divine nature. The focus was not on *death* but instead on the *new life and renewal* that came out of death.

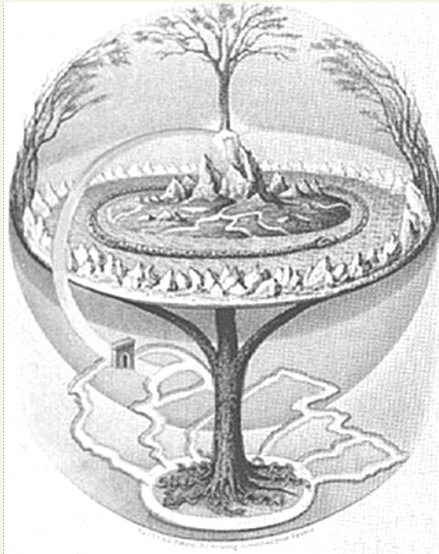
Halloween had some practical implications as well. It came at a time in the year when the days and nights are truly cold in northern Europe. The ancient Celts were first and foremost pastoralists, and by the time of Halloween would have guided their herds safely out of the high pastures of the summer and into the valleys and winter settlements below. Their herds would have been large however, and resources scarce, so any animals that seemed unlikely to survive the winter, or were unnecessary as breeding stock would be slaughtered, and their meats smoked, salted, and preserved for winter.

The traditions we still carry on today that honor the dead originate in a time and culture where it was just as important to honor those cow, grain, and vegetable spirits who have crossed over as it is to honor those humans who are no longer with us. The Celts, as most indigenous peoples, believed that all of creation was imbued with spirit, not just the human element. As all indigenous peoples they acted in ceremony and belief in accord with the natural cycle of the earth. Samhain marked the death of the green world for the winter season. It sent many animals into hibernation, plant spirits deep into the earth with their roots and seeds, and began the dance of the wild hunt.

The wild hunt was thought to be at large in the winter half of the year. This practice was echoed in Germanic tradition and in many of our symbols and practices it survives to this day. Among the Germanic tribes of northern Europe this hunt was thought to be lead by the old all father god, Woden and his consort. This consort had many different names: Nerthus, Perchta, Frigga, Hel, Hulle, etc. In the lands along the Rhine River however, she was called Holle. She was goddess of hearth and home, of motherhood, fertility, earth itself. It was she who watched over the health and safety of children in life, and she took and cared for their souls after death.

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Woden was the all father of all the gods. He had given his right eye in sacrifice to receive the wisdom of the runes as he hung on the world tree for nine days. With his one eye he watched out over all the people of the earth, all the gods, all the elves and giants. In the summer his spirit was believed to live in the green world, his union with earth bringing abundance to all the creatures of creation. In the winter, though, the spirits of both Woden and Holle were freed with the harvest. No longer bound to the cycle of the green world, they began their procession through the human world.

It is interesting to note that in Pre-Christian times this procession was not figurative or mythological- but real in the physical world. Tacitus, a Roman general who wrote around 100 AD described this procession. The human incarnation of the Goddess Nerthus emerged with her consort from her underground dwelling after October 31st. This Goddess incarnate then made a procession throughout the Germanic lands through the Yule tide. Interestingly, all people were expected to lay down their weapons, and cease any fighting or warfare until after this time (don't let mom see you fighting or you're in trouble!). Those who were caught fighting with weapons were punished with death. After Christianization these processions ceased in the physical world, but the world of myth, folklore, and spirit they continued their ride.

In the winter season, both Holle and Woden were thought to lead separate processions of spirits through the world. Holle was followed by the spirits of children who had died (in Christian times this was limited to un-baptized children), and Woden by those warriors loyal to him who had died in battle or during the hunt. It is important to note that the spirits released from the earth at the harvest were both good and bad. So just as much as this was a time to honor loved ones who had passed, it was a time to protect against dangerous spirits as well.

On the (still) holy seasons of Halloween and the twelve days of Yule (now shifted from its original start date at the solstice to our modern Christmas date), the veil between the worlds of spirit and the world of humans was and is still thought to be the thinnest, allowing communication between the worlds. Despite the fact that in Germanic times the new year shifted from Halloween to Yule, Halloween's focus remained on communication with loved ones, teachers, and elders who had passed over. Since ancient times Celtic, and later Germanic people have used the nature of this day to honor, remember, and gain knowledge from the dead. Many in the modern world would see this practice as inherently evil, or at least scary, but to a people who did not fear death, to whom death was but a passing phase of life, and to whom all of creation spoke through the voice of Spirit; it was natural, essential, and beautiful.

Even in our modern culture, though the sacred and secular have largely become quite separate, this day is seen as a feast of the dead. In the Catholic, Anglican, Lutheran, and UCC Churches, the feast of all Souls day is an official church holiday, a time to pray for and honor those who have passed. It is a time to remember their deeds, their lives, their contributions to the world of the living. In modern Braucherei this day is still seen as a day of observation as well.

Though PA German culture did not take to the festive celebration of Halloween in early years (it was almost exclusively a church feast day and was observed with solemnity), after the massive immigrations of the Irish in the mid-nineteenth century Halloween traditions were introduced strongly into American culture. The Germans, as many others did, took to celebrating Halloween with gusto. The traditions of Halloween reminded them quite easily of their own Yuletide, Easter, and Walpurgisnacht festivities, and would have been greatly welcomed by an agrarian culture with a jolly reputation. There are many traditions of observation of the Halloween season in PA German culture, and particularly in Braucherei practice: Many Pennsylvania Germans believed that the Butzeman must be burned before the feast of Alle Liebe Ziel (All Hallows eve). Otherwise some less than friendly spirit could reanimate the scarecrow. Ghost stories persist to this day of the reanimated Butzeman wreaking havoc on unsuspecting humans. This current day tradition clearly echoes the ancient belief that it was only after the feast of Halloween that these sprits would be at large. On Alle Liebe Ziel many would set an empty place at the table for those who have passed. Among Brauchers this place was often for their beloved teacher. Some Brauchers would set little corners of remembrance to these teachers, with pictures and personal affects of their teachers along with candles, prayers, etc. One woman would even set out pie and a shot of whiskey in this corner on important feast days.

Brauchers also ready themselves for the dream world on Halloween night. In Braucherei it is taught that elders and teachers of the Braucherei way can come in dreams at any time to us. In many cases, this type of visitation can occur to relay a particular message. Other times, however, it is thought that teachers will come simply to make themselves available to the student of this path. Because of this, Brauchers are taught to always be ready with questions for their elders, so as not to waste such a rare opportunity. As Halloween is the night dedicated to the honoring and remembrance of the dead, Brauchers often go to bed with questions on their minds and lips, ready to engage the teachings of the elders should they be given the opportunity.

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Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore

In the household, mugwort was laid among clothes to repel wool moths and hung in the beams of house and barns to repel flies. Beekeepers also rubbed their hands with the crushed leaves to prevent beestings while working the hives.

Interestingly, mugwort was inserted into traveler's shoes to prevent fatigue and was also enjoyed as a foot-bath for tired feet and legs.

Stuffed into pillows, mugwort is used for insomnia and to promote dreaming. For children combine half chamomile and half mugwort.

References:

Compendium of Symbolic and Ritual Plants in Europe—
(2003)

Sauer's Herbal Cures -William Woys Weaver (2001)

Herbalpedia- Maureen Rogers at the The Herb Growing & Marketing Network Herbworld.com

MUGWORT

Artemisia vulgaris
Auldy Frau, Beifuss

Mugwort is an aromatic perennial herb that is native to Europe and Asia but has naturalized throughout the United States. Mugwort is closely related to the common wormwood, but may be easily identified by the leaves being silvery white on the undersides and bearing pointed leaf segments; Wormwood leaf segments are blunt and rounded.

Traditional medicinal uses: As a bitter tasting herb, mugwort has been used traditionally as a digestive tonic. It can be taken in low doses over the long term to improve appetite, digestive function and promote liver function. It also helps to increase bile flow, absorption of nutrients and encourage the elimination of intestinal worms. Although mugwort is extremely bitter, it has found it's way into European stuffings and dumplings for centuries. In Germany, it is a traditional spice for fatty sausages and roast goose, because of it's ability to aid in digestion.

Mugwort has long been used as a 'woman's herb' to balance menstrual irregularities, calm menstrual cramps, speed labor and to help expel afterbirth.

Topically, mugwort can be used as a warming liniment or poultice when applied to rheumatic and arthritic pains.

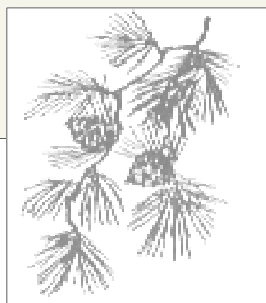
The Chinese use a smoldering stick of dry compacted mugwort (called a moxa stick) to bring warmth and stimulation to areas of the body that are cold and lacking circulation.

Candle Customs



“Bayberry candles burned
to the socket,
Bring health to the home
and
Wealth to the pocket”

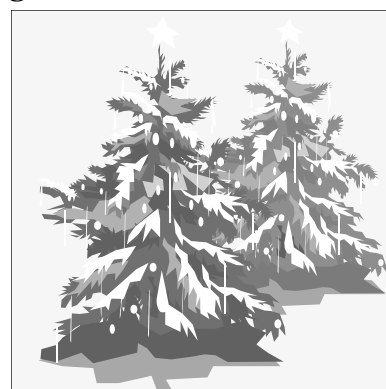
Bayberry candles were made by early American settlers from the wax of the berries of the Bayberry tree (*Myrica cerifera*) which grows along the sandy coastal areas from Maryland up through the New England states. Boiling the tiny autumn picked berries produces a thin layer of green vegetable wax on the surface of the water. The spicy scented wax is then skimmed and collected for candle making. It takes fifteen pounds of berries to produce one pound of wax. The settlers learned that the bayberry candles were worth the extra effort because they burned longer, cleaner and brighter than did the traditional beeswax or tallow candles of the time. Due to the amount of work necessary to make one bayberry candle, they were put aside to burn only on special occasions. Lit at sunset and allowed to burn down to the nub on Christmas Eve or New Year's Eve, they are said to bring good luck in the coming year. Very often they are given as housewarming gifts during the holidays. Legend has it that the Bayberry Tree gave shelter to the Holy family during a storm –therefore lightning is said never to strike it. Pure hand-dipped bayberry candles are available on line at www.abundanthealth.com . The candles are petrochemical free and the wick contains no lead.



The fir tree has
a long association
with Christianity. It

began in Germany almost a 1000 years ago when St Boniface, who converted the German people to Christianity, was said to have come across a group of pagans worshipping an oak tree. In anger, St Boniface is said to have cut down the oak tree and to his amazement a young fir tree sprung up from the roots of the oak tree. St Boniface took this as a sign of the Christian faith. But it was not until the 16th century that fir trees were brought indoors at Christmas time.

It has been long thought that Martin Luther began the tradition of bringing a fir tree into the home. According to one legend, late one evening Martin Luther was walking home through the woods and noticed how beautifully the stars shined through the trees. He wanted to share the beauty with his wife and children so he cut down a fir tree and took it home. Once inside he placed small lighted candles on the branches and said that it would be a symbol of the beautiful Christmas sky.



Jederebber Liebt Grischdaag-Everybody Loves Christmas

What could be more important to Christians than the birth of Jesus Christ? In days gone by, 17th and 18th century protestant English speaking society (in England and the United States) held Christmas with decided distaste. They believed (correctly) that the majority of Christmas customs came from pagan roots, and saw it as their duty as Protestants to root out this type of "evil" in Christian tradition. In Protestant English society most stores were kept open, there was no caroling, no Christmas parties, and no twelve days of anything. Often there was persecution for even holding a special church service for the birth of Christ. This puritanical abolishment of the Christmas celebration was contrasted vividly with the PA German Christmas celebrations, which lasted the whole Christmas season- from St. Nicholas Day until Epiphany Day. German Christmases were notoriously rowdy events filled with singing, feasting, sweets and stories. It is the stories, which hint at the true origin of this holiday as our yearly focal point, and its importance takes us back to the most ancient Germanic tribes of central Europe.

When the Roman Empire invaded Celtic Gaul in the second century BCE they set up the Rhine River as the Barrier between the "civilized" people of the empire, and the "Barbarians" to the north and east. It seems to have been this act alone, which created the initial division in culture between the Celtic and Germanic peoples. Until that time the traditions on both sides of the Rhine were nearly identical, but after this dramatic separation the shift began.

Among the aspects of culture that changed after this time are the feast days. In Germanic times the New Year came to be placed on the twelve-day feast of Yule. It was thought that this was the height of the strength of the Wild Hunt, and people feasted and celebrated from the day of Sonnenwenden (the "turning sun"-winter solstice) until twelve days later when the New Year began. This twelve-day period was traditionally a time outside of time. During Yule the human world of law and order was turned on its head. In truth the yuletide celebrations of the Germanic peoples came to be everything that the anarchic Celtic celebration of Samhain was already. Although the feast of the dead lived on among the Germanic tribes, it no longer also held the importance of the New Year season. These ancient ancestors began their year on the darkest day, orienting themselves toward the growth and renewal to come with the strengthening Sun.

Pope Julius I officially set Christmas on The 25th of December in 350 AD. Though this date is an unlikely date for the actual birth of Jesus (shepherds would not be in the high fields in the winter season), it was conveniently set to coincide with other winter festivals of various European peoples. The Christmas season was set to coincide with the Roman feast season of Saturnalia as well as the Yuletide season surrounding the winter solstice among the German and Celtic peoples of the north. More than anything else, this decision was an

attempt to ease the goal of the Christianization of Europe. In Roman culture it had long been the policy to allow local culture, language and religion to continue on....within the confines of Roman society. The Roman Catholic Church has generally had a similar take in its missionary work, allowing for local deities to survive as saints, agricultural (essentially pagan) feast days to be continued as holy days of obligation, and ancient myth to continue on as folklore. The words and terminology change, the flavor and meaning of the seasons do not.

With the strength of chaotic wild hunt at its height during Yuletide, people would spend the days feasting, singing, parading through the streets in costumes, joining in the chaos and anarchy of the hunt itself. Many of our most beloved Christmas traditions come from this time. Our feasts, our gatherings, singing and gift giving, have been with us since the most ancient celebrations of the turning sun. Even more beloved, though, are our symbols of this season: Christmas trees, the new son of god, stockings, Santa Claus (or the Belschnickel) and his reindeer and elves, the season of charity, of peace on earth and good will toward men. Our Pork and Saurkraut at new years, our mummers parades, our noisy, chaotic parties.... Have been with us as far back as our cultural memory can stretch, and long before the stories of Jesus found their way to the ears of our ancestors.

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The Wild Hunt Begins...

continued from page 10

Alle Liebe Ziel is also a time of banishing charms. Just as Brauchers use the energies of the moon every month for the energies of growth and decline, these same principals can be used in the larger cycle of the sun. In the Germanic calendar the year began at Yule, when the sun was at its weakest point, and beginning its cycle of growth. During this time people oriented themselves toward spiritual growth. During the time between the summer and winter solstice, however, the sun is on the decline, and people would choose some aspect of their lives or behaviors they wanted to leave behind to send with the sun as it waned into darkness. This is still a focus of the time between Alle Liebe Ziel and Sonnenwenden. In the cycle of the year Halloween was the time of banishing these unwanted and outmoded ways. These practices are still echoed in the modern practices of Braucherei. Halloween ceremony still holds its focus not only on the honoring of those who have passed, but on leaving behind those aspects of ourselves that are not in harmony with the Holy Spirit, the first half of the new years resolution (to be completed after Sonnenwenden). At Alle Liebe Ziel we remember that we are all mortal, and all come to death in the end. We use the ceremony and intention of this day to remind ourselves to live each day with intention, to guard against distraction from our God- given work, to strive toward unity between our lives and intentions and the wholeness of the Holy Spirit.

Jederebber Liebt Grishdaag continued

Although trick or treating is often associated with Halloween in modern culture, in Germanic culture it was and still is practiced more often at Christmas. The origin of this tradition- one still echoed in our practices of caroling, belschnickling, and wassailing at Christmas- comes from the belief that Holle and Woden would be at large with all of their charges during the twelve-day feast of Yule. Those who wished to have luck in the coming year knew to treat any visitor with kindness and compassion, often inviting visitors in and sharing food and drink. Often during this time visitors would be masked and costumed, and none could know for sure if the fellow who sat, ate, and drank was just a beggar, or Woden himself. This season of warmth and compassion towards others has in no way begun with Christian times, instead, along with many of our important cultural values, started with the ancient Germanic tribes of central Europe. For the above-mentioned reasons it was considered lucky to be charitable during the Yuletide, and many people shared already limited resources with unknown or undesirable guests during this time.

The story of the wild hunt may seem foreign to our modern symbols and stories at Christmas time, but it is this very story (which Germans refused to give up whether pagan, catholic, or protestant) that has given rise to our what has given rise to our modern day concept of Santa and Mrs. Claus, their red and fur lined adornments, their factory of adoring elves, and their flying reindeer. This story is far too complicated to explain in this small space, however, so I will refer you to another article in this newsletter: "Jolly Old St Nicholas".

The Christmas tree is probably the second most treasured symbol of this holiday, and again its roots are very old. Pre-Christian German peoples had always "decked their halls with boughs of holly", mistletoe, and any other evergreen they could find. These symbols served to remind them of the infinite power of life to overcome the darkness and cold of winter.

The original Christmas tree was not one of the fir or pine trees that are in common use now, instead, Holly trees were decorated and brought into the village square and sometimes even into the house. This is a tradition that takes came directly out of the tradition of the Upper Rhine region of Germany and France. We know that this tradition existed at least in the medieval times because of laws created to prohibit the practice in these areas as far back as the 14th century. The earliest documented record of a *decorated* tree also comes from this area. In 1605 a traveler to Strassburg, Alsace described "Dannenbaume" which had been decorated with paper roses, apples, wafers, sugar, etc.

The earliest Christmas trees in America, however, seem to have been put up by the Pennsylvania Dutch as early as the 1820's. Early Christmas generally trees stood on the table and the decorations were usually edible. There are many legends to describe how the Christmas tree was taken into the Christian tradition. One among these legends describes a woodcutter who helps a small and hungry child out of kindness. The child reappears on the following day, and reveals himself to be none other than the Christ child. This child gives the woodcutter the bough of an evergreen, and tells the man that this bough will become a tree, which bears fruit at Christmas time. The man and his wife plant the tree, and as foretold the tree is laden with nuts and fruit at Christmas. Another legend tells of Martin Luther who is said to have brought an evergreen into the house and illuminated it with candles. This vision was said to represent the starry sky from which the Christ child came. In all cases, though the legends remind us of the seemingly impossible promise of new life and salvation from the dark and cold of winter. How can one talk of Christmas and not describe the foods. The foods of Christmas, as everything else, have held importance to the German people as long as we can remember or record. Traditional Yuletide fare was most often pork in some form, or, if the weather wasn't cold enough for butchering, goose was the common alternative. It wasn't just on Christmas day that pork was served, but on New Year's Day as well, when it is made with sauerkraut and served for good luck.

Again, these food traditions have been with Germans as long as sauerkraut and beer. The pig, and especially the boar, was sacred to Woden who was the father god of all the Germanic people, and particularly ruled over things that were shamanic in nature. It was he and his consort, Holle (Perchte, Nerthus, Bertha) who led the Wild Hunt during the twelve days of Yule. Before the Yule feast men would join the hunt and killing a wild boar for their feast. The hunt and the butchering, as well as the cooking and feasting were community wide events among the Pre-Christian Germans. In ancient times these events would also have been highly ritualized, with portions of the meat burnt in offering to the gods of fertility. When eaten, the meat would have been seen as sacred food. This same process was true when the meat was Goose instead of Pork, though the Goose was sacred to Holle, not Woden, the same principals were implied.

Though these animals have long been domesticated, and few PA German butchers involve ritual elements in their butchering process, there are still echoes of the importance of these foods at our midwinter feast. The very fact that eating pork and sauerkraut at New Year's is a testament to this truth. Others can be seen in various northern European traditions: In many regions of Europe whole roast pig is still the traditional Yule feast; in Sweden yuletide cakes are still baked in the shape of a boar; in some parts of Britain hard, pink candy pigs are still made and given out after the Yule feast. These candies are smashed to bits with a large wooden hammer so that everyone can have a piece of the "sacrifice".

Continued on page 16....



Jolly Old St. Nicholas

In the current culture our beloved Santa Claus has become little more than a marketing tool during the Christmas Holiday season. But his weathered, caring face, his heavy coat of fur, and his plentiful gifts for all have been with us for centuries. His character is not entirely of Christian or Pagan origin, but is one of the greatest compromises in history between two warring faiths. Although this compromise is very easily seen throughout our holiday traditions, it is the Christmas Season, and Father Christmas in particular that show the continuity of tradition. As new ideas are introduced they are incorporated into the whole. Most often, though, little is lost from the older culture. I like to think of it as a layered cake, with each layer of cultural dominance placed upon the others, yet still allowing for the others. Truly, in order for new cultural concepts to be considered they need to be presented to a people in a way that does not threaten the old, otherwise they are simply not incorporated at all.

There have been so many attempts to completely annihilate entire cultures or ways of being. It is examples of cultural compromises like Father Christmas that teach us the true way of the folk. Regardless of when or where, the truth is that people are stubborn, they do not allow the unabashed destruction of their culture, but hold tightly to any familiar thread they can that reminds them of the once beautiful tapestry. Because of this fact we can see that culture is a continuously evolving living being. What would culture be if it were not for this fact? The soul of a people has a long memory, its symbols and teachings are rich with the wisdom of ages, how could we want it any other way? Santa Claus, or as the PA Germans call him, the "Belschnickel" is a convergence of two main characters: Woden, the all father of the ancient Germanic tribes; and St. Nicholas, the early Christian Bishop of Myra. Below is a chronological evolution of our current day St. Nick:

*In 100 AD the Roman General, Tacitus recorded the procession of the Goddess, Nerthus, and her consort through the Germanic lands after the final harvest. This time was one of peace and generosity in the lands of the Germanic tribes each year. This is the first record of the legend of the Wild Hunt.

*In the fourth century AD the young man now known as St. Nicholas was made a Greek bishop of Myra in Asia Minor (present day Turkey).

*Nicholas died in 343 AD, but was remembered for many things: He had spent his life helping the poor and under privileged, he loved children and he would frequently disguise himself in a cloak to leave anonymous gifts of money, clothing, and food for poor families.

*When he was sainted he was made patron saint of Children and seafaring, and because of sailor's love for him his fame spread as far as ships would carry his name. He was later also made patron saint of Russia.

*The ancient Saxons were known to hold 12 day feasts during their celebration of Yule- the time when the wild hunt was at its strongest. It was their belief that Woden and Holle were at large during that time of the year. During the feast of Yule they would choose a man to be the "Holly King", standing in Woden's stead. They would dress this man in furs and garlands of evergreens and he would be treated to a feast. More importantly, and easier to recognize was the practice of the Holly king to come to the feast with gifts for all those present. He would also sit and listen to the people present to learn whether or not they were contented and what would help them to make their lives more joyful.

*The time of Yule was a time of charity and gift giving, and one to forgive and forget the debts and grievances held against another- this was in honor of the presence of Holle and Woden. It was believed that they could come to any home in any disguise, the people of the house had to be prepared to share their blessings, lest they find themselves without in the coming year.

*In the mid ninth century the first chronicles of the life of St. Nicholas were written. Shortly thereafter the clergy at the Cologne Cathedral began giving fruit and cookies to the boys of the monastery on St. Nicholas's feast day, December 6th.

*Also on December 6th people of the Germanic lands and elsewhere would hold parades with St. Nicholas astride a white horse.

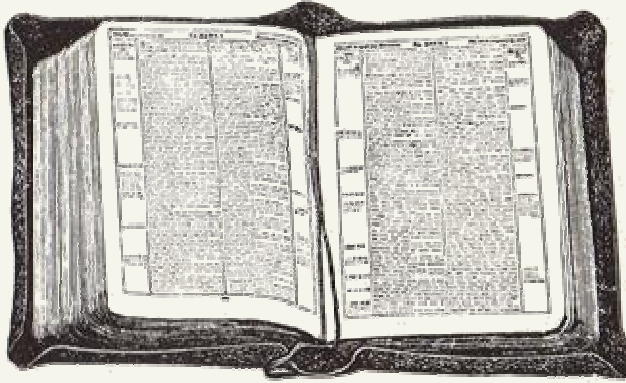
*The Germanic Christmas/Yuletide traditions spread throughout Europe along with the Vikings.

*By 1300 AD the characters of Woden and St. Nicholas had merged inextricably into the Germanic "Peltznickel" or "Nicholas in furs". His appearance was almost entirely that of Woden: the sleigh, the white beard, the fur coat, etc. In this guise he has developed many other names as well: the Frost King, Father Christmas, Jack Frost, etc. His consort was still Holle or Perchta, as she is called in parts of Bavaria and Austria. In many places in Europe it is still she who brings gifts at Christmas time, and in her name that children go trick-or-treat style (costumed as spirits or ghouls called "Perchten") begging for treats during the Yule time celebrations.

*By 1500 AD there were 700 churches named for St. Nicholas in Britain alone, in addition to ships, songs, and poetry in his honor. Although in Britain Christmas was banned in 1647 with the onset of Puritan rule, Christmas in the German lands continued as always, complete with Evergreens and Belschnickels. It is because of the Germans who came to the New world that our current conception of Santa Claus has developed as it has.

*Until the late nineteenth century, the Germans of Europe and America received their Christmas gifts from the Christ Child, not from the Belschnickel (in Germany this is often still true). The Belschnickel would drop in on December 6th to interrogate the children as to their behavior over the past year. Often they would have to perform in some way to gain the favor (and the candies!) of the Belschnickel.

*Despite the popularity of Santa in much of the United States, Belschnickeling was a favorite Christmas pastime among PA Germans, and the Belschnickel tradition continued up until the early 20th century. What would often begin as a single Belschnickel's outing routinely became packs of Belschnickels roving through the streets of the town, candy and whips in hand. The Belschnickel is still a popular image of PA German Christmas tradition, and he can come back if we let him in!



Ezekiel 16: 6

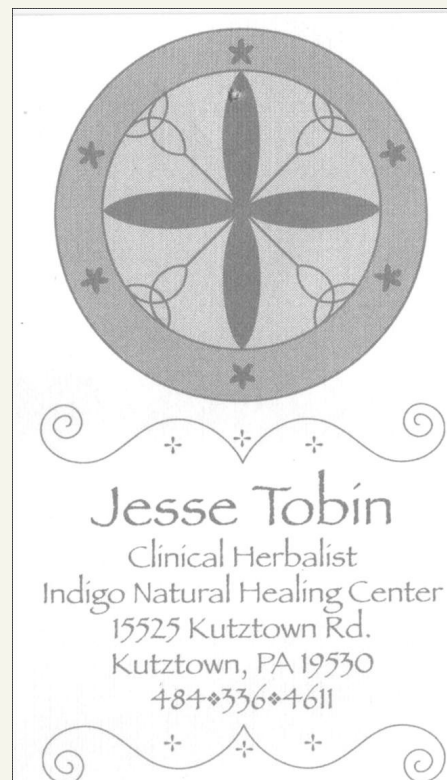
And when I passed by thee, and saw thee polluted in thine own blood, I said unto thee when thou wast in thy blood, Live; yea I said unto thee when thou wast in thy blood, Live.”

Ezekiel 16:6 is a passage from the Bible that has been used to “stop the flow of blood”. Called the ‘bleeding cure’, one must face east repeating the verse 3 times while including the full name of the injured or bleeding person. This cure has been utilized by folk healers and lay people over time, particularly the Scotch-Irish of the Appalachian Mountains and also those of PA German descent. In the original ‘Foxfire’ book first published in 1968, the final chapter is devoted to the practice of ‘faith healing.’ Those who practiced the art of ‘blood stopping’ were able to stop the flow of blood of a person or a farm animal and a few were even to cure across the miles with or without the use of a telephone. This verse can be learned and utilized by anyone who believes that it will work!

Grischdaag continued

Many people have difficulty with the Christmas season. For some it is too commercial, for some, too pagan, for some, too Christian, and of course, for some the season is just too stressful. For me, the Christmas season exemplifies the rich tradition of the Germanic people, and the PA Germans as part of that lineage. How amazing to see the evolution of the symbols, beliefs, characters, stories, and practices that we still hold dear. To know the origin of these heirlooms is to understand them more fully. This joyous feast of hope, charity, and forgiveness is an event that is part of the makeup of the lifeblood of our culture, and always has been, regardless of the structure of faith. I think Christmas reveals to us better than any other holiday, the continuity of the evolution of culture. The blood that flowed in the veins of our ancestors, the language that flowed on their tongues, and the culture that flowed in their lives is what gave rise to all that has come since their time. The symbols that served them before the time of Christ continue to teach the Christian tidings, and the stories that remain from the legends of their time still serve us as we raise our children in a culture of humility, charity, forgiveness, and appreciation of the spark of god that resides within the heart of all the living.

At Yule the sun turns to the cycle of growth, and as the birth of the Son of God reminds us, as the sky is filled each day with more light, so should we turn to fill our own souls with the light of the Holy Spirit, and truly take the gifts we are given in the darkest days.



Der Braucherei Weg “the Braucherei Path”

One of the biggest problems we have come to face in our research and revival of the Braucherei tradition has been the training of new Brauchers. One issue is that we truly need to educate and train many new Brauchers in order to ensure the survival of the practice. On the other hand, however, we simply cannot train new practitioners indiscriminately. In an effort to fulfill several of our goals at once....namely educating as many as possible *about* the tradition, and creating a pool of eligible apprentices who would be able to *carry on* the tradition... we have created a full year course in the history, evolution, and theory of the Braucherei tradition.

This course will provide an overview of the history and evolution of the unique spiritual and healing traditions of the PA Germans. Students will explore the historical roots of Braucherei from Pre-Christian times to the present. In particular they will focus on the evolution of the mystical cosmology through the many waves of cultural influence in both Europe and America. Students will explore the relationship between the rural nature of the PA German people and the structure and function of the Braucherei tradition. They will also survey the theory and practices of Braucherei. Most importantly, students will engage in an active discussion of the ongoing resystemization of this living but severely fragmented tradition.

Those hoping to become apprentices in the Braucherei tradition through the Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts will be required first to complete this year-long course. There are several reasons for this: 1) the year long course will provide us the opportunity to acquaint ourselves well with each student, and their potential strengths and weaknesses as Brauchers; 2) the course will be designed to give students a complete understanding of the cultural and historical context of this tradition, and thus its value as an asset to the culture; 3) the year long cycle of the course will begin students on a spiritual journey that may or may not result in apprenticeship, but will aim to bring each member of the class group to a place of greater self reflection, 4) the course will endeavor to engage students in the process of cultural reclamation and revival.

‘Der Braucherei Weg’ course will begin in early February, 2008 and meet one Saturday monthly throughout the year until the following January, 2009. The cost for the course will be \$700 for the year. The course will be taught in the Kutztown area by Jesse Tobin. For more information, or to register call Jesse at 484-336-4611. The registration deadline will be January 15th 2008.

Course Goals:

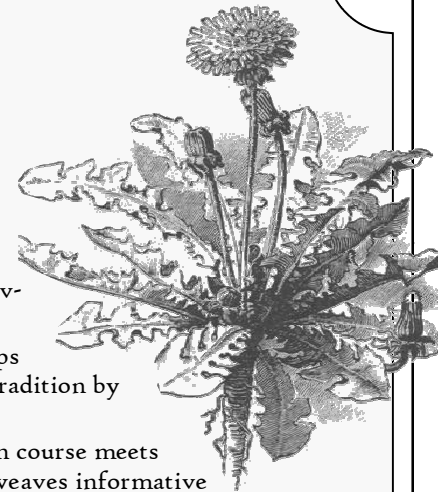
- Introduce students to the history and evolution of PA German Mysticism, occult wisdom, and healing practices
- Introduce students to the theory and cosmology of the Braucherei tradition
- Acquaint students with the scope of the Braucherei tradition by sharing prominent beliefs and practices of the tradition
- Engage students in an active dialog about folk cultural evolution
- Prepare students for future apprenticeship in the Braucherei tradition should they choose to pursue it.

The curriculum will include:

- Pre-Christian history and contributions to the tradition from the Roman, Celtic, and Germanic peoples
- Jewish and early Christian influence on the tradition
- German Mysticism of the middle ages
- Greek influence upon the tradition
- History and Mystical traditions of the reformation
- Early Pennsylvania Braucherei
- Native American influence
- Twentieth century Braucherei
- Differentiation between Braucherei and Hexerei
- The decline of Braucherei- Industrialization, Hex Trials, World Wars 1 and 2
- Cultural revival
- Survey of the current day tradition
- Cosmology and world view of modern day Brauchers
- Physical prayers
- Visual prayers
- Prayers in the world of spirit
- Folk herbal tradition
- New trends in Braucherei and the ongoing resystemization of the tradition

Exploring the Fine Art of..... **HOMESTEAD HERBALISM**

An eight month foundation course



In the not too distant past, keeping a family strong and healthy with simple home remedies was a common homesteading skill that every woman possessed. Identifying and utilizing wild and cultivated plants was as important and necessary as preserving food for the winter months or learning to stitch.

The "Homestead Herbalism" foundation course was designed to gather small groups of women (and yes, a few men!) with the intent of re-introducing this empowering tradition by learning together, using our hands, and preparing and sharing the herbal harvest.

Farm at Coventry's informative eight month "Homestead Herbalism" foundation course meets one Saturday every month from March through October. The course curriculum weaves informative current herbal wisdom with interesting historical facts and folk traditions. Through the seasons, from planting through harvest, we will learn to create delicious, nutritional snacks as well as therapeutic preparations using edible, medicinal and fragrance herbs that are both cultivated and wild crafted. Our time together will give students basic herbal knowledge and skills that will empower them to use herbs for their own nutritional, therapeutic and creative needs. Our teaching areas include a cozy classroom/farmhouse herb kitchen, cultivated gardens on our farm and the fields and forests of northern Chester County, Pennsylvania.

Students will receive approx. 56 hours of instruction, a large spiral ring notebook, plentiful handouts and recipes and a wide variety of take-home herbal preparations made together in class. A beautiful certificate will be presented at the completion of the course.

The curriculum includes but is not limited to:

- *Identifying and utilizing common backyard and wild plants
- *Planting, Harvesting, Wild-crafting, Drying, Preservation and Storage
- *Using herbs as Foods, Tonics and Medicines
- *Learn the Fine Art of Tea Making- exploring Infusions & Decoctions
- *Experiencing Tasty and Nutritious Herbal Treats and Recipes
- *Large spiral ring notebook containing 50+ in-depth Plant Specific study sheets
- *Herbal Glossary, Book Recommendations, Networking and Resources
- *Simple Overview of Body Systems and Therapeutics for the:
 - *Digestive System
 - *Nervous System
 - *Circulatory System
 - *Immune System
 - *Female Reproductive System
- *Topical Applications: Poultices, Compresses and Plasters
- *Time in the kitchen: teas, infused oils, salves, syrups, cordials and more
- *Herbal First Aid Kit/Kitchen Cabinet Remedies
- *Preparing for the Cold and Flu Season
- *Short Field trips and more.....



For more detailed information
or to register for the course visit
www.FarmatCoventry.com
or call 610-469-9591

The 2008 Calendar will begin with the February 23rd Guild Gathering.

The topic will be "Ceremonies for Major Life Transitions"

For more details and registration, watch for additions to our website

www.ThreeSistersCenter.com in the new year.



Henk die Geng-Deck the Halls

Henk die Geng mit Neschte Blanze, Fa la la la la la la la la

Sis die Zeit fer Leit zu danze, Fa la la la la la la la la

Geb mir all die scheene Gleeder, Fa la la la la la la la la

Sing die alt zeit Grischdaag Lieder, Fa la la la la la la la la

Guckemol der Block aa brenne, Fa la la la la la la la la

G'droff der Harf un kling die Glocke, Fa la la la la la la la la

Kumm all rei fer luschdig Blessier, Fa la la la la la la la la

Kumm un drink un schwetz bei nanner, Fa la la la la la la la la

G'schwind verbei geht es alt Yaahr, Fa la la la la la la la la

Griess die nei Yaahr as iss gebore, Fa la la la la la la la la

Sing mir frehlich all mit nanner, Fa la la la la la la la la

Gebnix drum fun Wind un Wedder, Fa la la la la la la la la

Reprinted from the Pennsylvania Dutch Christmas Carols Songbook
published by the Pennsylvania German Cultural Heritage Center

Translation by Paul Kunkel 2006

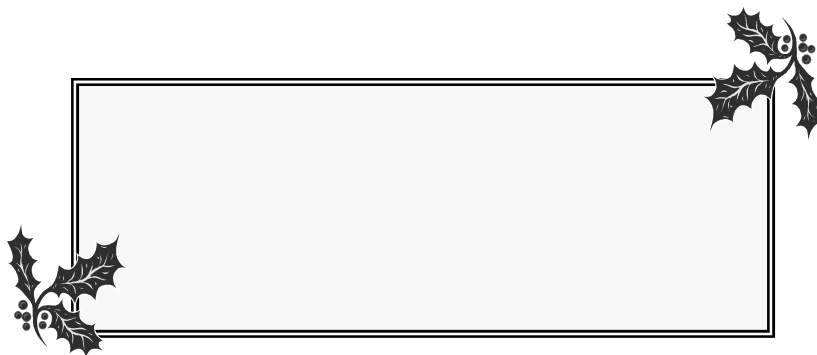
Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts

Farm at Coventry

1333 Ridge Road

Pottstown, PA

19465



Visit our website: www.ThreeSistersCenter.com

Pennsylvania German Soft Gingerbread Cake

3 cups unbleached flour
1 teaspoon baking powder
2 teaspoons ground cinnamon
2 teaspoons ground ginger
1 teaspoons ground cloves
1/2 teaspoon ground nutmeg
1/2 cup butter
1 cup sugar
2 eggs beaten
1 cup dark molasses
1/4 cup boiling water
1 cup buttermilk

Preheat oven to 350 degrees. Sift the first six ingredients together and set to the side. Cream the butter until soft. Add the sugar, a 1/4 cup at a time, mixing between each addition. Cream until fluffy. Add half the eggs, beating well. Then beat in the other half. Mix the water and molasses together well and then gradually blend into the butter mixture. Add the dry ingredients a little at a time until well blended and then slowly add the buttermilk, mixing in until well blended. Pour gingerbread batter into a 13 X 9 cake pan. Bake at 350 degrees for 35 minutes or until a toothpick comes out clean. When cool sprinkle with confectioner's sugar.

